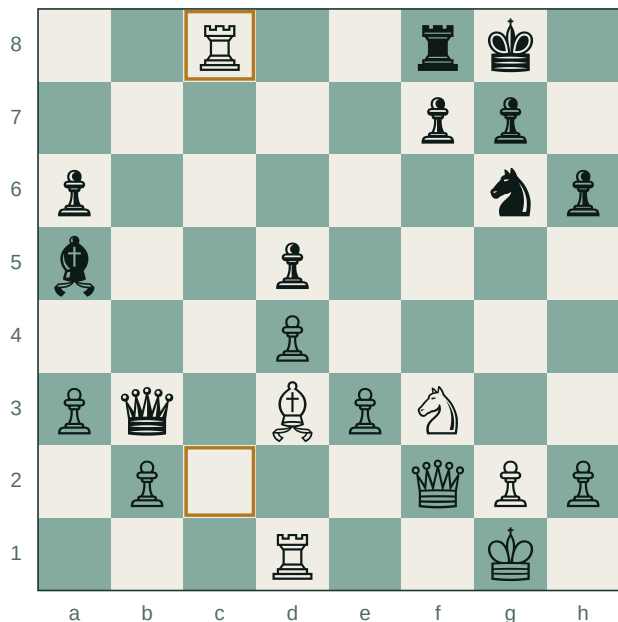


Loose-piece tactics: Black, move 26

Loose-piece tactics

Black to move



Previous move: 26.Rxc8. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

26...Qxd1+ 27. Qf1 Qxf1+ 28. Kxf1 Rxc8

26...Qxd1+ Check restricts White to 4 legal replies here. From d1 it attacks king on g1, knight on f3 and bishop on d3. Recorded reply: **27.Qf1**.

27...Qxf1+ Check restricts White to 2 legal replies here. From f1 it attacks king on g1, knight on f3 and bishop on d3. Recorded reply: **28.Kxf1**.

28...Rxc8 The rook captures the rook on c8.

At the end, nominal material is White 12 / Black 16 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, Black's balance changes by +10. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

CHECKPOINT

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does Black's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer: +10:** the balance goes from -6 to +4. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

A piece may appear hanging because its defender is indirect: taking it might allow mate, a fork, or a stronger capture.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

An undefended or tactically undefendable piece can turn an ordinary position into a combination. The first task is to distinguish a truly free capture from a poisoned one.

HOW TO LOOK

List the loose enemy pieces and check whether a forcing move can expose or attack more than one of them.

The defending king is on g1. Geometrically undefended: rook on c8 and rook on d1. Check for tactical protection.